The Book of Inquiry

Draft v2 – Expanded Journey

This draft expands the first stages of the journey with findings after each major prompt. It is intended as the beginning of a much larger handbook.

Stage 1 — Hidden Project Architecture

Prompt Goal: Instead of asking an AI to build a project, ask it to discover the hidden architecture that makes implementation dramatically simpler.

What We Learned:
• Difficult projects are often difficult because they are represented poorly.
• The highest leverage is finding the invariant before writing code.
• Architecture is compression: one abstraction can remove hundreds of implementation decisions.

Correction:
We initially optimized for execution. We realized the real bottleneck was representation.

Lesson:
A better representation can make an impossible project become a routine engineering task.

Questions:
- What assumptions define this project?
- What can be removed without reducing capability?
- What single abstraction simplifies everything?

Stage 2 — Opportunity Discovery

Prompt Goal:
Search for a high-leverage opportunity instead of brainstorming features.

Findings:
• The model naturally searched for infrastructure rather than applications.
• It repeatedly moved toward bottlenecks rather than products.
• Valuable opportunities often exist where incentives, technology and institutions intersect.

Weakness:
The first opportunity looked elegant but lacked evidence.

Lesson:
An opportunity is only interesting if reality supports the bottleneck.

Stage 3 — Falsification

Prompt Goal:
Destroy the previous theory.

Findings:
• The model became substantially stronger after attacking its own assumptions.
• Several attractive analogies failed.
• Confidence decreased while quality increased.

Lesson:
Theories improve by surviving criticism, not by accumulating supporting arguments.

Wisdom:
'A theory becoming smaller can be progress.'

Stage 4 — Reality Audit

Prompt Goal:
Separate evidence from speculation.

Findings:
• The methodology introduced evidence ledgers.
• Time horizons were separated.
• Predictions became dated and measurable.

Major Insight:
Reality should not merely inspire theory—it should continuously revise it.

Lesson:
Elegant explanations without measurable predictions are incomplete.

Stage 5 — Discovery Engine

Prompt Goal:
Understand how discoveries happen.

Findings:
• No universal discovery algorithm emerged.
• A universal discovery process did:
Compress → Predict → Reality Veto.

Additional heuristics:
- Hunt anomalies.
- Change representation.
- Demand mechanisms.
- Compare rival theories.

Lesson:
The value lies in a disciplined search process, not guaranteed discoveries.

Where We Go Next

Rather than writing more prompts, the next versions of the handbook will expand every stage into a complete chapter containing:

• Original prompt.
• Why it was written.
• Raw model output.
• Critique.
• What survived.
• What failed.
• Historical parallels.
• Generalized methodology.
• Practical applications.
• Open questions.
• Exercises for the reader.

Target size:
80–150 pages.

Each iteration of the book should improve the methodology itself, not merely add more content.